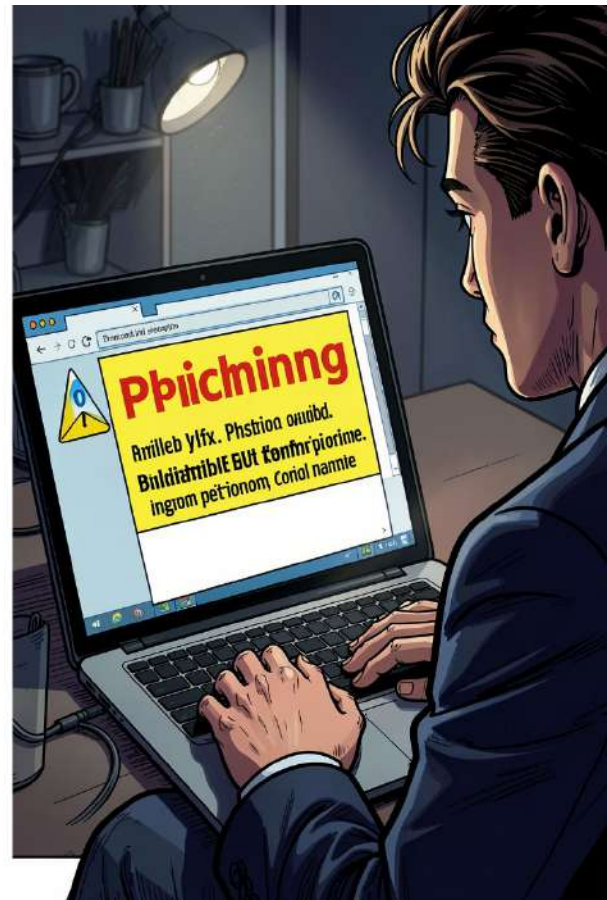


Phishing Awareness Training

How to Recognize & Avoid Phishing Attacks

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What is Phishing?

Phishing is a fraudulent attempt to steal sensitive data by posing as a trusted entity. Attackers seek usernames, passwords, financial details, or access tokens. Often the first step in larger breaches—credential theft can lead to unauthorized system access, data loss, and identity theft.

Primary Goal

Trick users into revealing credentials or installing malware.

Common Vectors

Email, SMS, phone calls, and fake websites.

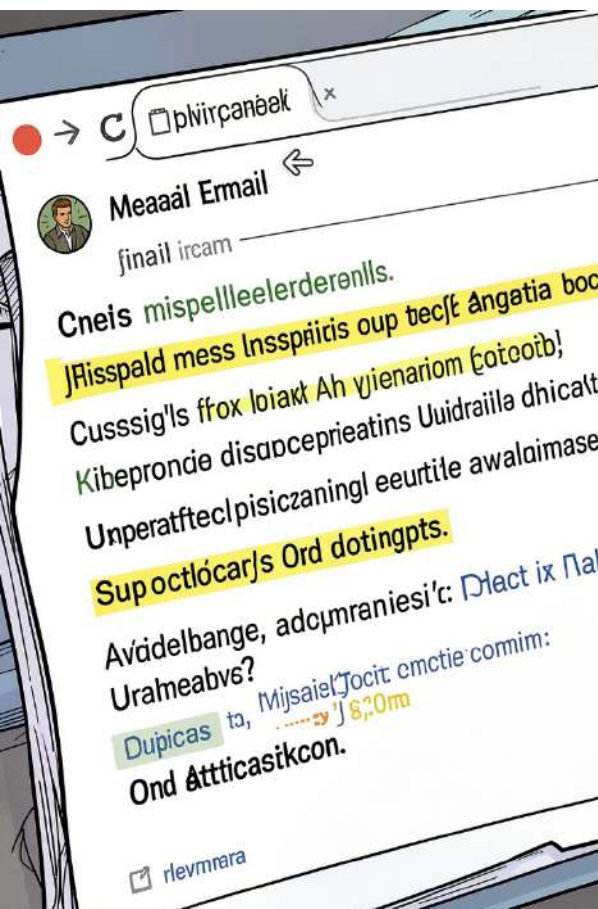




Types of Phishing

- Deceptive Phishing — mass emails impersonating banks or services.
- Spear Phishing — highly targeted, personalized based on research.
- Whaling — executive-targeted attacks for high-value access.
- Vishing & Smishing — voice calls and SMS messages used to deceive.

i Spear phishing often bypasses filters because messages look legitimate to the recipient.



How to Recognize a Phishing Email



The Sender Trap

Look for domain misspellings, odd subdomains, or display-name spoofing that masks the real address.



Urgent Language

Threats of suspension or urgent requests push victims to act before verifying.



Suspicious Links & Attachments

Hover to preview URLs, avoid opening unexpected attachments, and treat shortened links with caution.



Real Example: "Urgent Security Alert"

Case study: recipient receives a branded-looking message titled "Urgent Security Alert." Key red flags—the visible sender differs from the reply-to domain, greeting is generic ("Dear user"), and a high-pressure CTA urges immediate password reset.

Anatomy of the Attack

- Mismatched sender and reply-to domains
- Generic greeting and inconsistent branding
- Shortened or obfuscated URL leading to credential-harvesting page

Outcome

Users who clicked were led to a cloned login page; harvested credentials enabled lateral movement into internal systems.



How to Spot Fake Websites

Verify the URL: Confirm exact domain spelling (watch subdomains), prefer bookmarks for important sites, and inspect for HTTPS and valid certificates.

The "Too Good to Be True" test: Unexpected pop-ups requesting credentials are almost always malicious. Legitimate sites rarely ask for passwords via email or unsolicited overlays.

- **Browser Cues**

- Certificate warnings or expired certs
- Inconsistent branding or low-quality images
- Requests for unusual data (PINs, full SSNs)

- **Quick Checks**

- Use a second device to verify a suspected site
- Search site name + "login" to compare official URLs



Social Engineering Tactics



Authority

Scammers pose as IT, HR, or government officials to bypass skepticism and demand compliance.



Scarcity & Urgency

Limited-time threats or offers pressure fast action and reduce verification behaviors.



Emotional Manipulation

Fear, curiosity, or excitement weaken judgment—attackers exploit emotions to trigger mistakes.



Best Practices to Stay Safe

Use Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA)

MFA blocks attackers even when passwords are compromised—enable on all critical accounts.

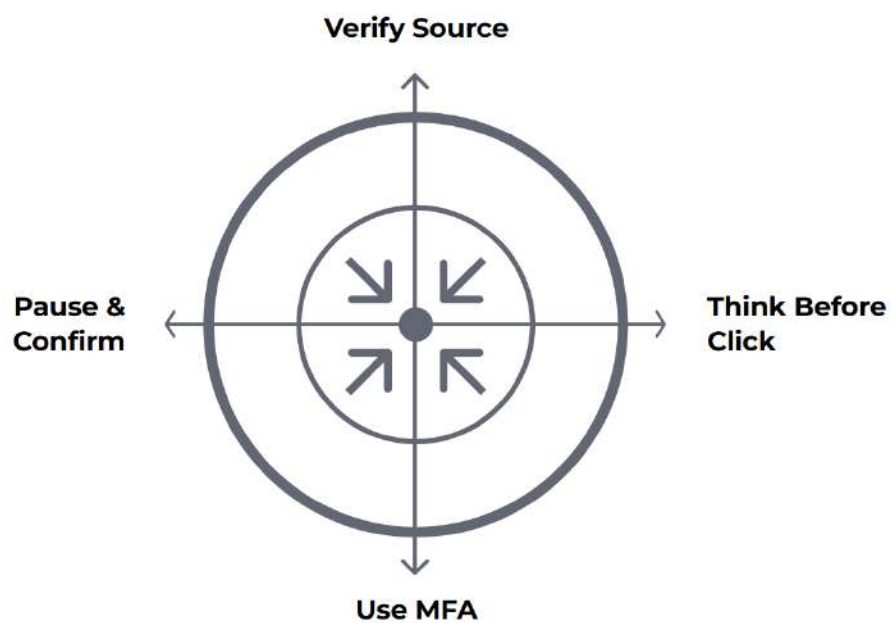
Verify Before You Click

Hover links, check sender domains, and confirm requests through a separate channel.

Report Suspicious Activity

Immediately notify IT/security and preserve the original message for forensic review.

- ☐ Keep software and browsers updated; phishing often exploits known vulnerabilities.



These three habits form a simple daily checklist: confirm who is asking, pause to evaluate urgency or oddness, and use multi-factor defenses to reduce the impact of stolen credentials.



Stay Vigilant

The cyber landscape evolves, but most phishing still targets human behavior. Take ownership of your digital security—awareness, verification, and proper controls make you the strongest defense.

Questions?

Contact CodeAlpha IT security or your internship supervisor for follow-up and reporting procedures.

Resources

Bookmark the company security guide, enable MFA, and subscribe to security alerts.